Root Cause Analysis

Dig beneath a recurring problem with a fishbone and 5 Whys, check the cause, and test a fix.

Improve · Fishbone (Ishikawa) Diagram · 5 Whys · Fix the System, Not the Person

TEAM _____

DATE _____

1 The Problem

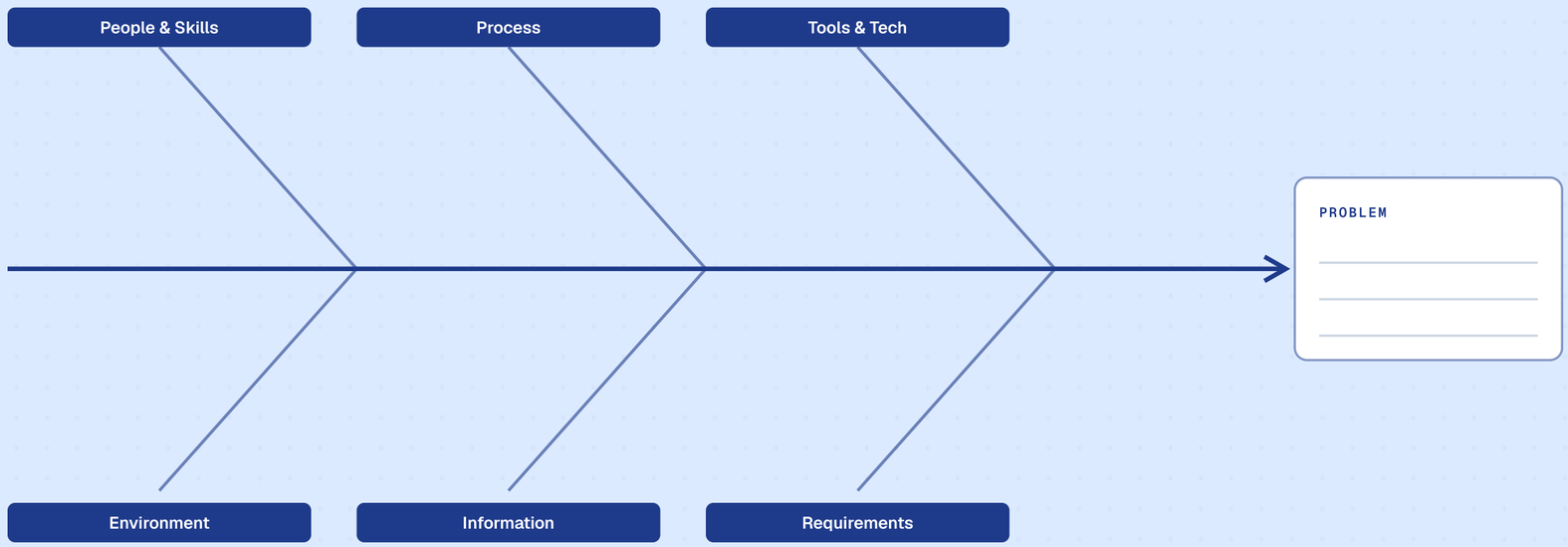
FACTS, NOT BLAME

What happened: _____ When, where, how often: _____

Impact: _____

2 Fishbone

STICKIES ON THE BONE THEY BELONG TO



3 5 Whys

ASK WHY UNTIL YOU REACH A CAUSE YOU CAN FIX

Why 1? _____

↓ Why 2? _____

↓ Why 3? _____

↓ Why 4? _____

↓ Why 5? _____

Root cause: _____

4 Check the Cause

BEFORE YOU FIX IT

- [ ] If we fixed this, would the problem stop?
- [ ] Do we have evidence, not just opinion?
- [ ] Is it about the system, not a person?
- [ ] Is it within our control or influence?
- [ ] Would it explain other problems too?

Any "no"? Ask why again, or test another branch.

5 Countermeasures

SMALL, TESTABLE FIXES

ACTION	OWNER	BY WHEN

6 Did It Work?

We'll measure: _____

Baseline: _____

Check on: _____

Result: _____

- [ ] Fixed
- [ ] Better
- [ ] No change

"Why does this keep happening, and what in our system lets it?"

"If we fixed the cause, what else would get better?"

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